continuously higher standards of living to the Chinese people. A phase of decelerating growth may generate internal tensions. This may be the reason why the Party has adopted a more nationalist stance on a range of foreign policy issues, even though it may be counterproductive. Xi has also adopted a more populist economic strategy, catering to the middle classes and discouraging extravagant display of wealth. He may also be justifying his relentless accumulation of political power as Party leader by pointing to the need for an iron hand to deal with the serious and multiple challenges the country and the Party are confronted with. Therefore, appeals to national pride are coupled with warnings of acute dangers and multiple threats to China. This does not mean that a collapse of the one-party state is imminent. The one-party state can persist for a long time and can prove to be adaptable, as Deng showed, but eventually success in expanding the metrics of power, as China has done, brings its own contradictions in its train.

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China under Xi Jinping is trying to square the circle by presenting China's one-party Leninist state as the most successful model of governance, worthy of emulation by other countries. The disarray in which the liberal democracies of the world find themselves in has created an opportunity for China to display the superiority of its authoritarian system. If enough countries sign on to the Chinese model, if international norms can be altered to reflect the political preferences of China, then this may reinforce the legitimacy of the model within China and deflect external pressures from rival centres of power, particularly the US and its Western allies. This link between the compulsions of a one-party Leninist state and the drivers of its external posture should be understood.

It is likely that at the Twentieth Party Congress to be held in October 2022, Xi Jinping will succeed in winning another term as the country's top leader. There are signs, however, of opposition building up against his claim to uncontested power. No Leninist state has been able to put in place a mechanism for the orderly and non-violent transfer of power from one